

CHANDANA MOHAN
RAO

65, RETAILER

CHAIRMAN, C M R GROUP

TURNOVER IN 1985 Rs 60 crore

CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 1,000 crore



A PRABHAKAR RAO

humble BEGINNING

CMR dropped out of school when he was in Class VIII. His first salary was Rs 22 a month.

success MANTRA

The single point sourcing of all material ensures cost-cutting and better pricing.

white FETISH

Mohan Rao is always dressed in white, which extends to even his slippers.

WEAR THE MONEY IS

When he began life as a salesman at a cloth store in Rajahmundry, Andhra Pradesh with a salary of Rs 22 a month, Chandana Mohan Rao's (CMR) dream was to run a retail store of his own. Sensing his commitment, his mentor, a textile shop owner, Bommanna Ramachandra Rao, helped him set up a cloth store in 1968. "Ensuring high quality, offering a wide range and keeping the prices reasonable are important for success in any retail business," says Mohan Rao. With these words in mind, he recorded unprecedented sales and the booming business of his first store made him open a second one, exclusively for silk saris, in Rajahmundry in 1976. By then his brothers learnt the nuances of the textile trade and it helped him to move out of the town to open Chandana Brothers in Visakhapatnam in 1985. As aspirations rose, so did his expansion. Today, CMR is a household name for fabric, readymade garments and even gold in Andhra Pradesh, with 54 stores and two malls and an annual turnover estimated to be more than Rs 1,000 crore.

Latching on to the changing trends, he introduced the mall format in 2005 to make CMR outlets a one-stop shop. To maximise profits, while selling at reasonable prices, he sources directly from the manufacturers.

Spartan in his lifestyle, Mohan Rao is always dressed in white, which extends to his slippers. He begins the day by praying to the sun god. To him his 1,100 employees are no less important than the consumers. That he is usually around talking to the customers is a big motivation for his staff. "All those who do well must give back to society," says the textile tycoon. And his way of giving back is to help poor, intelligent students with scholarships. The son of a tailor, who had to drop out of school to start work, doesn't want others to suffer silently. **by Amarnath K. Menon**